



Valorant's Unreal Engine 5 Update

A blessing for my PC, a curse for my bandwidth

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I've been hooked on Valorant since the beta, hours spent lining up Sova darts on Ascent and raging at my own whiffs in ranked. It's my go-to fix for that 1v3 clutch adrenaline. So when Riot announced the Unreal Engine 5 switch with patch 11.02, I was hyped for sharper visuals and smoother play, but also bracing for the usual patch-day chaos. Here's my straight take on what changed, and what it means.

The update was a brutal 21 GB, and on my average Wi-Fi it crawled, an entire evening watching a progress bar while clearing out 55 GB of SSD space just to make room. The payoff, though, was massive: after install, Valorant slimmed down to around 25 GB. Riot's promise about UE5 compression cutting redundant files delivered, finally freeing space for my neglected Steam backlog. My SSD practically sighed in relief. Still, if you're on slow internet or a data cap,

this patch probably felt as punishing as a ranked match against a smurf.

Loading into my first Comp on Haven didn't feel like a visual revolution, but the upgrades were there if you looked. Lumen lighting made shadows sharper, abilities like Omen's step and Phoenix's wall glowed more dynamically, and Jett's smokes caught light in a way that added subtle immersion without distraction. Maps felt livelier, yet still true to Valorant's clean style. Performance held steady, 180 FPS even with bumped-up settings, slightly faster load times, and no stutters during chaotic teamfights. For a game where every frame



counts, that smoothness might be the best upgrade of all.

The update wasn't flawless. The bumped minimum specs (i3-4150/Ryzen 3 1200 with 4 GB VRAM) hit some of my squad hard—one friend's GTX 1050 could barely keep up, turning their game into a blurry mess. Bugs piled on too: flickering Reaver Vandal textures, a crash during agent select, and Reddit blowing up with complaints about laggy queues, glitched skins, and shaky hit-reg. Abyss even had FPS drops from unoptimized Nanite geometry. Riot patched things fast, but those first 48 hours were rough unless you had a strong setup.

One concern I had was visual clarity. Valorant's chaos—Kay/O nades, Breach stuns, Raze rockets—already pushes the screen to its limits. With UE5's flashier tech, I worried textures and shadows might muddy the action. So far, Riot's managed the balance: Lumen adds flair without clutter, and outlines stay clear through smokes and walls. Still, there were hiccups, like Sage's wall blending into Abyss backgrounds until a hotfix. If future maps lean too heavily on Nanite detail or foliage, clarity could suffer, especially for low-end players dropping settings. For now, the balance holds, but it's worth watching.

The bigger picture here is potential. With Nanite, Valorant could eventually push into more complex map designs, interactive features, stuff that could change how rounds play out. I'm also curious about what this means for console-PC synergy. The engine shift feels like future-proofing. For now, the real gains are practical: a halved file size, smoother performance on mid-range rigs, and maps that feel more alive without losing clarity. Low-end players and those hit by launch bugs definitely suffered, but Riot smoothed things out fast. It's not perfect, but it keeps Valorant sharp without losing its addictive core, outplays, clutch moments, and that chase for the next rank. *